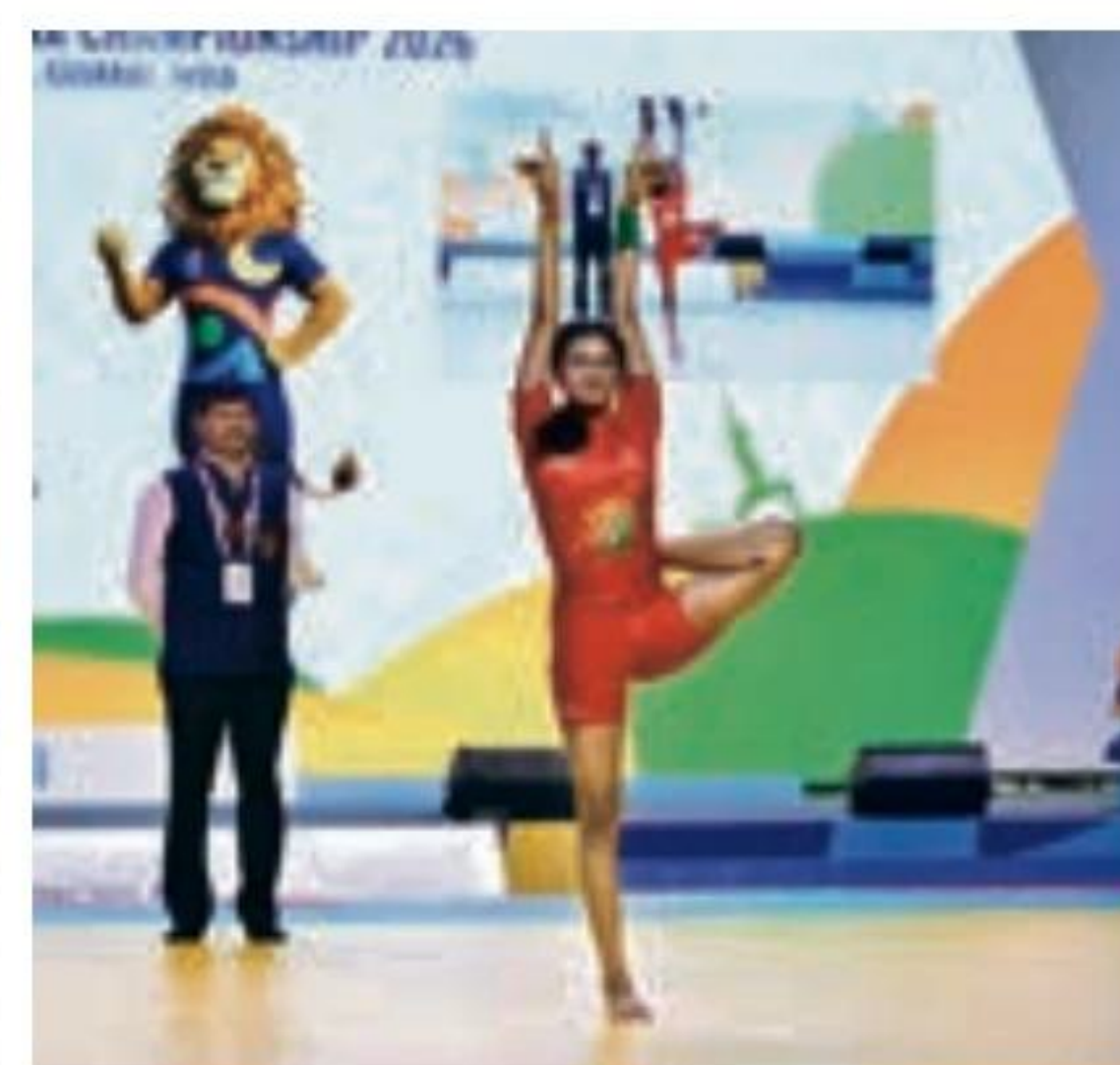




Technical grace: The tournament's Code of Points features more than 200 *asanas*, each judged on the precision of execution, the length of the hold, and the quality of the transitions into and out of the posture. PICS: VIJAY SONEJI

Stillness under the spotlight

Noise and silence, movement and composure coexisted at the **World Yogasana Championships**, where an ancient discipline embraced modern competition.

Karan Pillai

karanpillai.m@thehindu.co.in

One of the first things I noticed upon entering the EKA Arena, the venue of the World Yogasana Championships in Ahmedabad, was the striking contrast. While the event carried the energy and anticipation of any global sporting spectacle, complete with a vibrant multicultural opening ceremony, beneath the glare of the lights and the roar of the crowd there was a steely calm in the eyes of the participants — almost meditative, marked by unwavering focus and quiet confidence.

Once the athletes took the stage, the festive atmosphere gave way to one of intense concentration and composure. The arena seemed to oscillate between opposites: noise and silence, movement and composure, celebration and introspection. It was a convergence of multiple moods, each existing in perfect balance with the other. It was this balance that more than 500 athletes from nearly 80 countries sought to achieve over the course of the five-day event.

One couldn't miss the historical significance of the occasion. Yogic traditions date back thousands of years, their roots stretching deep into the civilisational history of India. Yet here they were, presented within the framework of a modern world championship, complete with national teams, judges, rankings and medals. The competition felt less like a reinvention of the practice and more like an intersection of heritage and high-performance sports.

In its inaugural edition, the tournament, organised by Yogasana Bharat in association with World Yogasana and the Indian Olympic Association, arrived with a well-defined rulebook. A total of 250 *asanas* — selected from the millions described in traditional yogic scriptures — formed the basis of competition and were evaluated by a panel of judges against established technical and artistic criteria.

"*Asanas* can vary according to different texts and traditions, but we have referred to both ancient and modern sources," said Umang Dawn, the event's Competition Manager. "We have drawn from Patanjali's texts, B.K.S. Iyengar's *Light on Yoga*, *Asana Pranayama* by Swamiji, and many other references. We are also standardising the names of certain *asanas* so that they are universally understood and linguistically accurate."

Udit Sheth, President of Yogasana Bharat and Vice-President of World Yogasana, noted that the *asanas* performed at the event differed significantly from those commonly associated with the practice. "It's not just touching your toes and doing a